The -n command-line option wraps whatever else is sent to the Ruby interpreter in a while gets; <INPUT>; end loop. This is frequently a single line passed in using -e, but it doesn't have to be, you could have a script file that processes a single line of input and use -n to apply that script to an entire input.

Now, looking at it, that puts statement seems like boilerplate, and it turns out there's a shortcut for that as well…sort of:

```
ruby -pe '"line: #{$_}"' < testfile
This is line one
This is line two
This is line three
And so on...
```

The -p option behaves like n, but also prints the line as it is being input, not the line that we are processing, which is sometimes helpful.

There's one more twist to the looping input, which is -a, for auto-split mode. With -a set, the incoming gets line is automatically split using String#split and the result goes into the global $F. The default delimiter is space, but you can set a delimiter with the command-line option -F, as in -F"\n". So:

```
$ ruby -nae 'puts "line: #{$F}"' < testfile
line: ["This", "is", "line", "one"]
line: ["This", "is", "line", "two"]
line: ["This", "is", "line", "three"]
line: ["And", "so", "on..."]
```

and:

```
$ ruby -F"i" -nae 'puts "line: #{$F}"' < testfile
line: ["Th", "s ", "s l", "ne one\n"]
line: ["Th", "s ", "s l", "ne two\n"]
line: ["Th", "s ", "s l", "ne three\n"]
line: ["And so on...\n"]
```

And just to clear one thing up—the options can be stacked if they don't have any arguments, so -nae is identical to -n -a -e.

If no filename is present on the command line or if the filename is a single hyphen, Ruby reads the program source from standard input.

Arguments for the program itself follow the program name:

```
$ ruby -w - "Hello World"
```

In this snippet, -w will enable warnings, then Ruby will read a program from standard input, and pass that program the string "Hello World" as an argument. We'll talk in a moment about how to deal with incoming command-line arguments.

Ruby Command-Line Options

Following is a complete list of Ruby's command-line options roughly organized by functionality.